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COL-314701

Mental Autolysis

Mesmer Jr.: Relax. This is just a psych evaluation.

Consultation Room, Rehab Center

Mesmer Jr., busy preparing the exam room's equipment, only glances at her patient.

Ms. Stranger: Don't worry, Ms. Mesmer. I understand this is a rather difficult situation for you.

Ms. Stranger: Someone who has joined Manus Vindictae more than once is hard to trust—one who's worn the mask twice, doubly so.

Ms. Stranger: But Foundation secrets aside, I'll tell you whatever you wish to know.

The camera's light locks onto its subject, illuminating her pupils gold.

Mesmer Jr.: I'm a therapist, Ms. Stranger, not an interrogator.

Mesmer Jr.: We just need to ensure the Manus mask hasn't left you with any dangerous after-effects.

Mesmer Jr.: You don't have to answer every question truthfully. I won't be fact-checking you. Just treat this like a normal, everyday conversation.

Once she's triple-checked the pupil readings, Mesmer Jr. turns her attention to the questionnaire.

Mesmer Jr.: First question. You're walking barefoot across a snowfield, white as far as the eye can see.

Ms. Stranger: Is this supposed to be about the Antarctic incident?

Mesmer Jr.: No, it's just a standard question to measure your emotional response.

Mesmer Jr.: Back to the scenario. You're hungry. You haven't eaten in three days. A snow hare approaches you.

Mesmer Jr.: It seems to think you're one of its own. It curls up beside you, sharing its warmth.

Ms. Stranger: This is cruel, but given it's a question of survival, I'd grab it.

Mesmer Jr.: Next question. You're sunbathing at sea when a sudden wave drags you into unfamiliar waters.

The subject's emotions are as controlled as Mesmer's voice—textbook, even.

Question, answer, question, answer … About 40 camera flashes later, the room finally goes quiet.

Mesmer Jr.: *sigh*

Ms. Stranger: Were my answers that bad?

Mesmer Jr.: Not at all. Both your responses and emotional display are within acceptable ranges.

Mesmer Jr.: But they're too consistent. Keeping micro-reactions that uniform across these kinds of questions is, frankly speaking, unheard of.

Ms. Stranger: That would be the fruits of my training.

Ms. Stranger: I'd usually add a little laugh here, a frown there, but perhaps recent events have left me tired.

Mesmer Jr.: If I sign off on this report, every department is going to suspect I faked it.

Mesmer Jr.: You need to answer with genuine emotion.

Ms. Stranger: I would if I could, Ms. Mesmer.

Ms. Stranger: But such training sticks. You might as well ask me to change the way I breathe.

Ms. Stranger: Would it help if I tried answering similar questions with different emotions?

Mesmer Jr.: I'm not signing off on a falsified report, Ms. Stranger.

Mesmer Jr.: Lie down. We'll continue under guided Artificial Somnambulism.

Ms. Stranger: Of course. My memories are yours to explore.

She reclines as though she's settling in for a cozy afternoon nap.

Artificial Somnambulism, start.

Ms. Stranger: So, where shall we begin?

Mesmer Jr.: Are you talking to me?

Ms. Stranger: There's no one else here, is there?

Mesmer Jr.: At this setting, you shouldn't be conscious.

Ms. Stranger: Further fruits of my training, I'm afraid. Couldn't risk divulging secrets in my sleep.

Mesmer Jr.: Lucid dreaming can be an early sign of dissociation, not something to be proud of.

Ms. Stranger: It's not a matter of pride; it's just how things are. But don't worry about me. In all the years I've been like this, it's never caused any problems.

Mesmer Jr.: I should know to expect the unexpected at this point.

Mesmer Jr.: Anyway, I'll record everything as it is.

Mesmer Jr.: Let's start with your earliest childhood memory.

Ms. Stranger: That would be my days at the SPDM.

From the void of her mind emerges a classroom with spotless black-and-white-checkered floors.

SPDM

Instructor: Today is your first official day here at the SPDM.

Instructor: I've read your files, but I'd like each of you to introduce yourselves.

Instructor: It will help you get to know each other and understand yourselves better.

Instructor: We'll go in seating order. When it's your turn, please stand and introduce yourself. Name and arcane skill will do.

Chairs scrape rhythmically against the tile as the nervous children stand and sit.

The instructor watches, nodding after each introduction, until the rhythm is broken by the girl sitting next to the window. She rises from her seat in one smooth motion and notably without scraping.

Kora: My name is Kora. My arcane skill is conjuring fire.

Ms. Stranger: I remember lying when I enrolled, claiming I could conjure fire.

Ms. Stranger: It wasn't until I dodged the arcane aptitude exam three times that they realized something was wrong.

Instructor: Kora, do you know why I asked to speak with you?

Kora: Yes, ma'am. It's because I'm an arcanist.

Instructor: You're a good child, Kora. There's nothing wrong with how you were born.

Instructor: You've achieved top marks ever since you arrived here, surpassing all your fellow classmates.

Instructor: Even in a human school, you'd be a top student.

Instructor: I know that I've taught you all not to misuse arcane skills.

Instructor: But that doesn't mean I want you to suppress your skills. On the contrary, I hope you can learn to control and wield them as you would any other tool.

Instructor: Everything else about your performance is excellent. If you follow my guidance and show control over your arcane skill in the next test—

Instructor: I can request to move you up a grade. You'd be able to graduate early, go out, and see the world. Wouldn't you like that?

Ms. Stranger: But come exam time, I just stood there in the middle of the field, like before, silent, motionless.

Ms. Stranger: That's when the school started to suspect I wasn't really the "Kora who can conjure fire."

Mesmer Jr.: I've never heard of anyone like that at the SPDM.

Mesmer Jr.: A case like yours would've made waves. Why has no one ever mentioned you?

Ms. Stranger: The Foundation erased my records, deleted my name from the graduate list, and even removed my face from every group photo.

Ms. Stranger: For a spy, having a past is a liability.

Mesmer Jr.: I'm sorry for what you went through, but this still doesn't make sense.

Ms. Stranger: I wouldn't dwell on it. For all I know, this may not even be a true memory, or at least, not one of mine.

Mesmer Jr.: You mean ...

Ms. Stranger: My long-term memory has been unstable lately. Too many people's pasts are jumbled in my head.

Ms. Stranger: Mhmm.

Ms. Stranger: I tried recalling some classmates' names, but all I got were John, Smith, and Doe.

Ms. Stranger: Seems it is indeed a false memory.

Mesmer Jr.: That would point to a psychological disorder.

Ms. Stranger: Hmm. This part—this feels real.

The scene blurs again, reshaping itself in the void.

Ms. Stranger: I should've been an ordinary girl from Iceland.

Ms. Stranger: My favorite thing in the world was Bolludagur—cream bun day. I'd whack my parents' backsides with a paper-covered stick, shouting "bolla, bolla, bolla!" to get a cream bun.

Ms. Stranger: My second favorite thing was going to Broadway with them.

Mesmer Jr.: Wait, Broadway?

Ms. Stranger: Oh! I'm sorry. Iceland doesn't have Broadway, does it?

Ms. Stranger: Let me correct that. I grew up in New York.

Ms. Stranger: Or was it San Francisco? I remember there was a big Chinatown near my home.

Ms. Stranger: My Chinese wasn't very good, so I'd always end up ordering too much.

Ms. Stranger: Delicious as the grilled meat with chimichurri was, there was no way I could finish seven portions on my own.

Mesmer Jr.: Chimichurri isn't Chinese food, though. It's Argentinian.

Ms. Stranger: You mean to say I'm from Argentina?

Mesmer Jr.: *sigh*

Seeing she's getting nowhere, Mesmer Jr. cuts off the memory.

Mesmer Jr.: Well, we've established that your childhood memories are full of inconsistencies. That's enough for now.

Mesmer Jr.: Dwelling on them will only put more strain on you.

Mesmer Jr.: I suggest we move forward. Focus on memories you're certain about.

Ms. Stranger: The parts I'm certain about? Yes, I can do that.

Ms. Stranger: Whatever my childhood was like, everything from one particular day onward, I've never forgotten.

Ms. Stranger: Because I met an alien that day.

Mesmer Jr.: What?

[English text unavailable]

COL-314702

Artificial Metamorphosis

Ms. Stranger: That was ten years ago.

???

The scene shifts into darkness, broken only by the glow of a TV screen with static storming across it.

Ms. Stranger: Mhmm.

A girl wakes to find herself strapped into a tilted restraint chair. The bindings render any attempt to struggle useless.

Ms. Stranger: When I opened my eyes, everything around me was pitch-black. All I could see was a TV and a single light bulb hanging overhead.

Ms. Stranger: A device held my head in place and my eyelids open. I had no choice but to stare at the fuzzy screen.

Ms. Stranger: Just as I started to think I was dreaming, I heard heavy footsteps.

As her story unfolds, a pair of red lights flicker in the darkness.

???: The drug has taken effect. We can begin.

???: Are you awake? Are you comfortable?

The voices sound distant, like they're coming from deep underwater.

Ms. Stranger: Where am I? Who are you?

Ms. Stranger: I'd heard enough stories to know what was happening. I'd been abducted by aliens. I was aboard their UFO.

???: You won't be able to move for a while, so it's best you settle in ...

Ms. Stranger: I couldn't help but think of Colorado's cattle mutilation cases from the 70s. Aliens had abducted entire herds of cows, taken their body parts, and left the corpses to rot in the fields.

Ms. Stranger: My imagination ran wild. I saw myself drained of blood, dissected, organs removed, and then discarded as a hollow shell.

Ms. Stranger: But strangely, even as I thought of all that, I didn't feel afraid.

Ms. Stranger: Their glowing eyes in the dark, their low voices ... They made me feel calm.

Ms. Stranger?: I know what you are. You're aliens.

Ms. Stranger?: Are you going to dissect me? Am I going to die?

???: Yes, we're aliens. Are you not afraid of us?

Ms. Stranger?: Should I be?

Ms. Stranger?: What does fear even feel like?

???: You're not afraid because you know you don't need to be, and you're right.

???: We can be friends.

Mesmer Jr.: You're sure they were aliens?

Ms. Stranger: Absolutely, Ms. Mesmer. They exist, and my abduction proves it.

Ms. Stranger: They'd probably been on Earth for a long time, given how fluent their English was.

Ms. Stranger: Though, I was unable to understand everything they said. Their vocabulary was a bit too advanced for my age.

Mesmer Jr.: Aliens might well exist, and plenty of people in Laplace believe they do.

Mesmer Jr.: But what I'm questioning right now is your mental state.

Mesmer Jr.: Did you experience anything traumatic as a child? Like abuse or abduction?

Ms. Stranger: Abduction? Only from the aliens themselves. And even if they tried to cover their tracks ...

Ms. Stranger: I'm certain these memories are real.

Mesmer Jr.: *sigh*

Mesmer finds herself caught between frustration and a strange admiration for such a perfectly structured yet utterly abnormal psyche.

Mesmer Jr.: What happened after that? Between you and these alleged aliens?

Ms. Stranger: Not "alleged," Ms. Mesmer. This was not some weather balloon being mistaken for a UFO. I saw them up close. They were real.

Her sincerity takes Mesmer Jr. by surprise.

Mesmer Jr.: No comment. Please, continue.

Ms. Stranger: No. Not until you admit they were indeed aliens.

Ms. Stranger: Insisting Earth and its creatures are all alone in the universe is a bit sad, don't you think, Ms. Mesmer?

Mesmer Jr.: What I think is irrelevant. I can't submit a report saying you were abducted by aliens to the Foundation.

Mesmer Jr.: They'd say I've finally lost it.

Ms. Stranger: Mhmm.

For the first time since the session began, Mesmer Jr. sees her patient pause in contemplation. Perhaps accepting the idea of these extraterrestrial kidnappers will help stabilize her.

Mesmer Jr.: Well, it's not impossible that you encountered something like that.

The occasional white lie is, according to both protocol and treatment guidelines, permissible at impasses such as this.

But Ms. Stranger has taken this acceptance and run with it.

Ms. Stranger: How about this?

Ms. Stranger: We include an objective description of them in your report to make it sound more credible.

Ms. Stranger: For example, humanoid creatures with gray-white fur, antennae, and glowing red eyes.

Ms. Stranger: Something like the Mothman.

Ms. Stranger: Actually, that might just work.

Ms. Stranger: If you don't want to call them aliens, we can call them Mothmen.

Ms. Stranger: Would wording it like that still get you into trouble?

Mesmer Jr.: Fine. Let's say you encountered something resembling Mothmen.

Mesmer resists the urge to rub her temples. She has to stay professional.

Mesmer Jr.: Can we continue? I'm getting tired.

Silhouettes manifest around the red lights—the Mothmen.

Ms. Stranger: Alright, where were we?

Mesmer Jr.: You were saying the ali—ahem, sorry, the Mothmen wanted to be your friends.

Ms. Stranger: Heh. Yes. And we had a bizarre yet joyful time together.

Mothman: We'd like you to watch something.

Ms. Stranger: Cartoons?

Mothman: Close. But they won't be quite so colorful.

Ms. Stranger: True to his word, the Mothman's "cartoons" were in black and white.

Ms. Stranger: The contents were mostly macabre, painful imagery, oddly juxtaposed with classical music.

Ms. Stranger: But if you held on until the screen turned white, you'd see happy, peaceful scenes.

Ms. Stranger: So I lay there, still strapped in the chair, holding my breath and waiting for the dark parts to end, then laughing when the light parts finally came.

Ms. Stranger: It was fun.

Mothman: She shows no discomfort in the face of disturbing stimuli.

Mothman: But when she's exposed to peaceful stimuli, her positive response is stronger than expected.

Mothman: That's where individualized instruction comes in. She's a quick learner.

Ms. Stranger: This continued for about 14 days. It was difficult to tell without going outside.

Ms. Stranger: By the 14th day, I was good friends with the Mothmen.

Ms. Stranger: I still couldn't leave the room, but they no longer restrained me in the chair.

Mothman: Starting today, you will begin receiving formal instruction.

Ms. Stranger: What will I be doing?

Mothman: Don't worry. The lessons are simple. Just do as we tell you.

Mothman: What you learn here will become your strength. And when the time comes, you will help many, many people.

Ms. Stranger: I learned a lot from them, much of which I rely on to this day.

Mesmer Jr.: So this is the "training" you mentioned earlier?

Mesmer Jr.: I thought it was the Foundation that trained you as a spy.

Ms. Stranger: You're a graduate yourself, Ms. Mesmer. You know the SPDM isn't equipped for such things.

Ms. Stranger: To teach you to hold your breath for prolonged periods or how to function without sleep.

Ms. Stranger: But the Mothmen ... They are natural masters of espionage. Any Foundation official would be ecstatic to receive their "gift."

Ms. Stranger: I proved it the minute I joined the Foundation.

[English text unavailable]

COL-314703

Ganglionic Control

Banquet Hall

"Lily": Thank you so much for inviting me today, Mr. Mountbatten.

Mountbatten: You're most welcome, Ms. Lily.

Mountbatten: Had I known that Braun had a daughter, I would've told him to bring you along ages ago.

Mountbatten: And you, Braun, why didn't you ever tell us about your lovely family?

Braun: Uh, well ...

"Lily": Oh, I know! It's because being married would make it harder to chat with the ladies you meet at work, right?

Braun: What?

"Lily": You don't have to pretend, you know. Mama's known for a long time. She just didn't say anything.

"Lily": I'm glad those partnerships never worked out, though. It would be terrible if they broke you and Mama apart.

Braun: Ah, yes. That was rather foolish of me.

Mountbatten: Hahaha! No wonder you've been so antsy today. I was starting to wonder what you were hiding.

Mountbatten: I'm very sorry to have put you on the spot, Braun, but I have to say, you had it coming. Be sure to make it up to your wife and daughter, eh?

Mountbatten: As for you, clever little Ms. Lily, your father and I still have much to discuss.

Mountbatten: Why don't you wait for dinner in the lounge? You can play with the cactus cat I got from the NewBabel Company.

"Lily": Really?! I'd love to!

Ms. Stranger: Mothmen are masters of infiltration and camouflage. You could have encountered them yourself, and you'd be none the wiser.

Forget your name. You're no longer your parents' child.

You can be anyone.

Ms. Stranger: They taught me how to become someone else, and I used that skill in my work as a Foundation spy.

Ms. Stranger: No one questioned Braun's awkward acting. Everyone just assumed he was embarrassed to talk about his personal life.

Ms. Stranger: No one suspected the rambunctious little "Lily," either. And the moths that appeared during our handshake? Mr. Mountbatten never even noticed them.

Ms. Stranger: By the time his staff realized someone had opened the safe, Madam Constantine was already reading through all his dirty little secrets.

Mesmer Jr.: So that was your first assignment as a spy.

Mesmer Jr.: But you skipped something. How did you join the Foundation?

Ms. Stranger: Oh, that part is simple. The Mothmen were wiped out by the "Storm."

Ms. Stranger: If memory serves me, it was after the fourth "Storm"? Yes, the fourth.

Mothman: We've lost contact with the first group of test subjects. A complete and utter failure.

Mothman: The plan is terminated. We're abandoning this safe house in one hour.

Mothman: And the remaining subjects?

Mothman: Leave them. All that matters now is destroying the records.

Ms. Stranger: Then, goodbye.

Mothman: No. Stay put.

Ms. Stranger: Then they took the TV away, and I was left in total darkness.

Ms. Stranger: I think I waited for three days? At least, that's how many times I fell asleep without instruction.

Mothman: I recommend this one.

Mothman: I assure you, she's the best and most loyal among them.

Constantine: Oh? Intriguing. What's her name?

Mothman: She doesn't have one. Her code name's been retired. Call her whatever you like.

Constantine: Then I'll call you ...

Ms. Stranger: And that's how I ended up joining the Foundation. Madam Constantine took me in.

Mesmer Jr.: So you were kidnapped by Mothmen and then sold to the Foundation.

Ms. Stranger: Please, don't say that.

Ms. Stranger: They took a homeless, amnesiac child off the streets. They gave her an education and a job.

Ms. Stranger: How is that any different from the SPDM's recruitment methods?

Mesmer Jr.: You're free to see it that way.

Mesmer Jr.: Now, tell me about your life after Madam Constantine took you in.

Ms. Stranger: Hm? Aren't you curious about the relationship between the Mothmen and the Foundation?

Mesmer Jr.: Would knowing that help me understand your psyche better?

Ms. Stranger: Probably not.

Mesmer Jr.: Then no. Again, I'm a therapist, not an interrogator.

Mesmer Jr.: Why don't we talk about your adoptive mother instead? Madam Constantine?

Ms. Stranger: I see. You prefer wholesome, human stories over spy thrillers.

Mesmer Jr.: Parent-child dynamics are a useful entry point for understanding psychological conditions. That's all.

Ms. Stranger: Oh! Sorry, I tried to shift the focus onto you. Old habits die hard.

Ms. Stranger: You're truly a responsible therapist, Ms. Mesmer.

Ms. Stranger: Alright. Let's talk about my loving yet strict foster mother.

Admin Office, St. Pavlov Foundation

Constantine: From today on, you are my daughter.

Constantine: Tell me, what can you do?

???: I can turn memories into moths with my arcane skill, then send them wherever I like.

???: And I can be anyone.

Constantine: Show me. Use your moths on me.

???: Understood.

The young agent doesn't hesitate. She reaches out and brushes a practiced hand against Constantine's, conjuring a moth onto it.

Constantine: Impressive. I didn't sense any arcane energy whatsoever.

Constantine: And you followed that order without hesitation, despite me now being your guardian.

???: It's wrong to disobey orders. And doing something wrong makes me feel sick.

Constantine: What if I ordered you to kill me?

???: How would you like to die?

Constantine: They trained you well. Seems I could learn a thing or two from them.

Ms. Stranger: That was how I began earning Madam Constantine's trust and the start of my work as her personal agent.

Ms. Stranger: What comes next involves too many of Madam Constantine's secrets. For Foundation-related memories, I suggest we stop here.

Ms. Stranger: Shall we move on to my time infiltrating Manus Vindictae?

Mesmer Jr.: Before that, answer me one question.

Mesmer Jr.: What do you think of Madam Constantine and the Foundation?

Ms. Stranger: Life with Madam Constantine was easy. She praised me when I did well, and as a child, that meant everything.

Ms. Stranger: As for the Foundation, I found its white and gray halls quite relaxing.

Ms. Stranger: As though I were living in the light parts of the Mothmen's cartoons, quiet and peaceful. A smile rarely left my face.

Ms. Stranger: It was a happy memory, I'd say.

[English text unavailable]

COL-314704

Hardly Herself

Forget Me Not: Are you ready, Ms. Grace?

Forget Me Not: Don't be afraid when you put it on.

Forget Me Not: So long as you truly believe in the Guiding One, so long as you truly reject the world as it is, you needn't feel any fear.

Forget Me Not: Though you now walk blind, the mask will be your cure. It will open your eyes to what truly matters.

Ms. Grace: Indeed. I don't feel fear. I simply want to treat this honor with the respect it deserves.

She stands in a dimly lit room under the watchful eyes of followers eager to see if she will join their ranks.

The gentleman stands beside her like a priest witnessing a baptism. With careful hands, she lifts the mask.

Forget Me Not: If you cannot let go of your terror, then let your hatred guide you.

Forget Me Not: Let your murdered parents—let the honor the humans stole from you—make the choice for you.

Ms. Grace: Phew.

She steels herself with a deep breath. Then, as if submerging herself into the baptismal water, she puts on the mask.

What comes next is calm. She does not suffocate. Her body and mind do not reject it. Her breathing remains steady.

The room is so quiet she can hear her own heartbeat. Then, it is broken by a lone burst of applause.

Forget Me Not: Congratulations, Ms. Grace. You're one of us now.

Forget Me Not: The Guiding One has accepted you.

Ms. Grace: Thank you very much, Mr. Forget Me Not.

Forget Me Not: Don't thank me. Thank yourself for accepting the trial. I merely offered the choice.

Forget Me Not: What fortune that my mercy has at last found the right recipient, that one more will stand with us as we witness the birth of a new order!

Ms. Grace: What fortune indeed! May the Guiding One lead us to the true future.

Ms. Stranger: As the last survivor of an arcanist family persecuted by humans, "Ms. Grace" was able to get close to Forget Me Not with ease.

Ms. Stranger: She gained even more of their trust after putting on the mask.

Ms. Stranger: Its trial would expose any traitors or nonbelievers or so they thought. They never doubted me for a second.

Mesmer Jr.: And the Foundation sees anyone who's worn it as a lost cause.

Mesmer Jr.: So far, you're the only exception. How did you manage that?

Ms. Stranger: Because I am a faithful believer in Arcana?

Mesmer Jr.: Repeat that joke again, and I'll have to call security.

Ms. Stranger: If humor is off the table, then I suppose I have no choice but to tell you the dreadful truth about the Mothmen.

Ms. Stranger: Their "training" extended beyond mere mental conditioning.

Mothman: How long did you sleep yesterday?

Ms. Stranger: Two hours.

Mothman: There's no clock in your room. How did you measure time?

Ms. Stranger: The sound of the tape. One loop takes 15 seconds. It played 480 times.

The Mothman doesn't respond. With the flip of a switch, the sole light illuminating the room goes out.

Mothman: Do you remember its contents?

She searches her memory. After a prolonged silence, she forces out an answer.

Ms. Stranger: I'm sorry. I can't remember.

Another flip of the switch. The light, dim though it is, frees her from the pitch-black abyss.

Mothman: Think again.

Ms. Stranger: Yes, I remember now.

She looks up at the lightbulb—the same as it was when she first arrived—and her throat, tongue, and lips produce words of their own accord.

Ms. Stranger: "All for the peace and safety of mankind."

Ms. Stranger: The Mothmen used specially designed pre-sleep audio and their arcane skills to mold my mind into something more resembling their own.

Ms. Stranger: As long as a "light" was switched on, I would be drawn to it.

Ms. Stranger: One light that never went out was that of the Foundation. It kept me acting as their agent.

Ms. Grace: And when I began my final mission, another light was switched on: Manus Vindictae.

Ms. Stranger: That is what turned me into Ms. Grace, a collector of corpses and despiser of humanity.

Mesmer Jr.: So you used self-hypnosis to become Ms. Grace, which fooled the mask into seeing you as a devoted follower.

Ms. Stranger: No, nothing like that. And before you speculate, it wasn't a split personality, either.

Ms. Stranger: It was merely an instinctive adaptation.

Ms. Stranger: Just as a moth is drawn to light, just as a dog salivates at the ring of a bell, I produced the thoughts and memories needed to fulfill my duty when the cue was given.

Ms. Stranger: Such conditioning meant there was no disloyalty for the mask to detect.

Mesmer Jr.: You're dismissing your own free will.

Ms. Stranger: A reasonable conclusion. I know it's difficult to wrap your head around, but the concept isn't a philosophical one.

Ms. Stranger: Perhaps a simpler explanation would be better. You can think of it as a clockwork mechanism inside my head.

Ms. Stranger: It ticked over, shaping my memories and generating my thoughts.

Ms. Stranger: It made me think and remember in ways that aligned with Manus Vindictae, leaving nothing for the mask's arcane power to detect.

Mesmer Jr.: Is it still controlling you now? Am I talking to the mechanism?

Ms. Stranger: It's gone.

Ms. Stranger: If it were still there, the Foundation would never have doubted my loyalty. And you wouldn't be interrogating me right now.

Mesmer Jr.: Again, this isn't an interrogation.

Mesmer Jr.: Anyway. If it's gone, then I'll assume I'm talking to the real you.

Mesmer Jr.: Tell me, how do you see Manus Vindictae now?

Ms. Stranger: Evil, repulsive black gunk.

Ms. Stranger: Though, to be completely honest, if not for all that darkness, they might have been more appealing than the Foundation.

Ms. Stranger: But let's continue. I can show you Manus Vindictae from the inside, along with how I really felt about them.

Ms. Stranger: Following the mask trial, things went pretty much as expected. Ms. Grace became a favorite of Forget Me Not, and I was quickly promoted to Apostle.

Basement, Unknown Location

Follower: Ah, there you are, my lady.

Ms. Grace: I hear you have a rather troublesome newcomer on your hands.

Follower: That's putting it lightly. She's dangerous, and she hasn't put on the mask yet. Be careful, my lady.

Several Manus followers surround a young woman, all gawking at her as if she were a wild beast in a zoo.

Ms. Kimberly: I'm not putting on that hideous mask! And I have no intention of joining you!

Ms. Grace: Is that so? I thought you'd find the mask quite appealing, given your unique taste in toys.

Ms. Kimberly: ...!

Ms. Grace: The follower who brought you here had a little accident. Unfortunately, this was all I could recover.

Ms. Grace: Given that it doesn't seem like his style, I'd guess it belongs to you, is that right?

Ms. Kimberly: Yes.

Ms. Grace: Good to know. Now then, what do you say to a calm little chat, hmm?

Ms. Grace: I'm Grace. What's your name?

Ms. Kimberly: Kimberly.

Ms. Grace: Heh. From your looks to your name, you seem like you walked straight out of a spy novel.

Ms. Kimberly: Wh-Where I come from is none of your business!

Ms. Grace: Oh, but it is. You've piqued my interest, Ms. Kimberly. Why not come to Texas with me? There's no better way to get to know each other than on a little road trip, after all.

Even with the rebellion of a stallion burning in Kimberly's eyes, the moment Grace pulls out the wind-up toy, she is reduced to a docile lamb.

Ms. Kimberly: As you wish.

Ms. Stranger: I recovered the contract item sealing Anjo Nala, or "Ms. Kimberly," as she called herself at the time, before the Manus followers realized what they'd stumbled upon.

Ms. Stranger: Thanks to the Foundation restricting the dissemination of succubus intel, Manus Vindictae's rank and file never understood the importance of that oddly cute wind-up toy. Securing it for myself was quite the achievement.

Ms. Stranger: She's much sweeter than she looks as long as she doesn't have her claws at your throat.

Ms. Stranger: Anyway, I ended up taking her to Route 77 to help in the preparations for the upcoming ritual.

Ms. Stranger: And that's where we ran into a series of small unfortunate events.

Hallway, Tuesday's Motel

Follower: H-Here we are, my lady. The others should already be waiting for you.

Kayla: I told you, you got the wrong girl! I ain't this "Grace" or whoever. I don't even know you!

Kayla: Where are you taking me?! Please, let me go!

Follower: Don't make this harder than it has to be.

A girl and a brutish Manus follower are locked in a standoff in the hallway.

Ms. Grace: Would you quiet down? The whole motel can hear ... Hmm?

Another woman, so alike she could pass for the girl's twin, emerges at the far end of the hallway. The arguing pair stares at her, stunned.

Kayla: Emm?

Follower: A-Another Ms. Grace?

Ms. Grace: Well now, I've read stories of doppelgängers, but ...

Ms. Grace: Never in my life did I think something so exciting could happen to boring old me.

Ms. Grace steps closer, carefully looking her "doppelgänger" over.

Ms. Grace: Hmm. Not exactly the same. But I'd wager most people wouldn't be able to tell the difference.

Ms. Grace: With a bit of makeup ... Yes, yes. I think this could work just perfectly.

Ms. Grace: I'm terribly sorry. My attendant must have mistaken you for me. It seems someone's due for an eye exam.

Kayla: So, it was all just a mix-up? Whew. Well, that's a relief.

Her shoulders relax, her panicked expression giving way to one of genuine surprise.

Kayla: My name's Kayla. Good you showed up when you did. Things might've gotten real ugly. Was just about to give this friend of yours a good clobbering.

Kayla: But who could've predicted something like this happening, right?

Ms. Grace: Yes. For a moment, I'd thought the motel's proprietor had put a mirror at the end of the hall to prank me.

Ms. Grace: Well, this makes for a memorable stay, at least. You can call me Grace.

Ms. Grace: Sorry for all the trouble. I'd invite you for some tea or coffee to make up for it, but I'm terribly busy today. I assume you'll be able to make it back on your own?

Kayla: It's okay! I'll be in town for a few days. Maybe we can grab a bite together when you're free.

Kayla: We look so alike. Who knows what else we might have in common, right? I'd bet we could be the best of friends!

Ms. Grace: Of course. I'll be sure to pay you a visit when I get the chance.

Collaborator: Why not invite her to stay for dinner, Ms. Grace?

Another figure peeks out from a doorway further down the hallway.

Collaborator: We just got some fresh ingredients—should be good.

Ms. Grace: Hmm. A lovely idea, but shouldn't we keep a low profile? And we ought to respect her wishes, especially given how rudely she was dragged here.

Collaborator: No use now. She's already seen our faces.

Collaborator: I'll ask her. Kayla, right?

Collaborator: We've got some time before dinner. Want to help us prep the stuffing?

Kayla: You bet I would! Count me in!

Ms. Grace: ...

Kayla: We can see what else we've got in common, Grace!

Kayla: Y'know, I always wondered what my life would've been like if I hadn't grown up on a farm.

Kayla: Seeing you now, it's like seeing another version of myself, raised somewhere else. I'm just bursting with questions. I don't even know where to start!

Ms. Grace: I'm afraid you might be disappointed. I can't say I grew up anywhere particularly interesting.

She falls silent, her eyes shifting from her "doppelgänger" to the hallway as she walks further.

Collaborator: From now on, don't send followers or believers to gather materials. They're too clumsy, too obvious.

Collaborator: Have the Order of Enlightenment handle it. They're better suited for this kind of work.

Collaborator: By the way, Ms. Grace, have you seen Kimberly? We've lost some materials. She might have taken them.

Collaborator: You need to bring her back before she eats them.

Ms. Grace: Yes. Kimberly is rather impulsive when she doesn't have orders, isn't she?

Ms. Stranger: After that, I had no choice but to assume Kayla's identity when going about town, to avoid raising suspicion over her disappearance.

Ms. Stranger: I thought it was some twisted joke fate had played on us both, but just like that, it was over.

Ms. Stranger: It was all beyond anything I'd anticipated. Truth be told, it was rather painful.

Mesmer Jr.: I take it you felt empathy for her? Given she looked just like you.

Ms. Stranger: I felt sadness and guilt, just as the Mothmen's training dictated.

Mothman: Based on her brain activity, she's fully grasped morality and loyalty.

Mothman: And if the two contradict each other?

Mothman: We'll deal with that when the time comes.

Ms. Stranger: But they also taught me that I had to complete my mission. Having two conflicting "lights" simultaneously switched on ... It hurt.

Mesmer Jr.: How do you feel looking back on it now that you're free?

Ms. Stranger: Now, I think there were plenty of other ways I could've handled that situation.

Ms. Stranger: I could've said she left or shifted the blame onto someone else. Anything would've been safer and more efficient than pretending to be Kayla long-term.

Ms. Stranger: Honestly, the motel owner likely saw through me from the start. Whenever she talked to me, she'd bring up legends about doppelgängers.

Ms. Stranger: As for why I made the choice I did, I think the real reason was Ms. Grace's penchant for "collecting."

Ms. Stranger: Or maybe, just like Kayla, I wanted to see what could've been.

Ms. Stranger: Meeting someone who looks so similar—it's like meeting another version of yourself.

Ms. Stranger: Looking at them, you can't help but imagine what life would be like in their shoes. And, naturally, you end up feeling envy, jealousy, and even pity.

Mesmer Jr.: Then let me ask: how did it feel "becoming" Kayla?

Ms. Stranger: She was different. At first, I was certain she was real. Her memories all held together. She gave me a chance to be a genuine person.

Ms. Stranger: But once I became her, I realized it was no different from all the other fabricated identities.

Ms. Stranger: They might have been real to others, but not to me.

Ms. Stranger: They weren't mine to have.

[English text unavailable]

COL-314705

All Her Memories

Countryside, Texas

Collaborator: Grace, give me the toy!

The collaborator crawls on the ground, eyes locked on the wind-up toy in Grace's hand. It's her only hope.

But it's lifted just out of reach, and with it goes her chance at survival.

Collaborator: You—!

In a flash, Kimberly snaps the collaborator's neck.

Ms. Grace: What a shame that the contract item only answers to its holder.

Ms. Kimberly: Why?

Ms. Grace: Hmm? Why what, Kimberly?

Kimberly flicks the blood from her claws. She tries to glare at Ms. Grace, but her brows can't help but furrow in confusion.

Ms. Kimberly: Why? Why did you do that? Why didn't you stop me? W-Weren't they your allies?

Ms. Grace: Oh, Kimberly. That last body's barely even gone cold. Why all the questions now that the deed is done? Besides, you got what you wanted, didn't you?

Ms. Kimberly: I wish you were all dead. If it weren't for that stupid toy, your neck would be next!

Ms. Kimberly: But, still, I don't understand you. Surely this isn't how allies are supposed to treat each other?

Ms. Grace: Tsk-tsk, such a temper. Can't you at least try to please me like you did your other masters?

Ms. Kimberly: How am I supposed to figure out what you want, you-you freak!

Ms. Grace: Ah, so that's how you are, is it? Seems my interests are beyond a naive, rude little girl such as yourself.

Ms. Grace: I'm glad to see you at least understand the word "ally," though. Perhaps there's still some conscience left in you after all.

Ms. Grace: Unfortunately, I don't have allies.

Ms. Grace: And as for what I want, I have an order for you.

She waves the toy back and forth, and Kimberly's trembling eyes can't help but follow.

Ms. Grace: Tell me about your sister, Mata Hari.

Ms. Kimberly: What? That's it? That's all you want?

The fear on her face turns to surprise, then into a bright, eager smile.

Ms. Kimberly: She was the best sister one could ever hope to have in the world! She taught me how to sing, and do makeup, and all kinds of fun games!

Ms. Grace: What about her work? I'm sure a legendary spy must have been quite busy.

Ms. Kimberly: Work? I don't know. She never told me anything about that. Maybe she didn't need to work?

Ms. Grace: How else would she get food, Kimberly?

Ms. Kimberly: When she was around, people always just brought it to us. And they didn't want anything in return, either, well, other than a dance.

Ms. Kimberly: So, maybe her job was dancing?

Ms. Grace: *sigh* This is pointless.

Ms. Grace: The next question isn't an order.

Ms. Grace: If you were free, where would you go? What would you do?

Ms. Kimberly: I'd snap your neck!

Ms. Kimberly: No, no! Sorry, forget that. I think I'd return to São Paulo. I want to go back to the Heartfelt Home.

Ms. Kimberly: I think there ought to be some people there who still remember me.

Ms. Grace: São Paulo. What a coincidence. That was your home?

Ms. Grace: When was that?

Ms. Kimberly: It's hard to say. I just remember the whole world was at war. All the chaos gave me the chance to slip away to São Paulo.

Ms. Kimberly: I lay low at the Heartfelt Home. Then the war ended, and I decided to stay there with the old folks.

Ms. Grace: That would've been around 1945. About 45 years ago.

Ms. Grace: The people you knew are probably long gone.

Ms. Kimberly: I know humans and arcanists don't live long, but there must be someone still alive! And it's not like I have anywhere else to go.

Ms. Grace: I don't just mean the natural passage of time. São Paulo's seen multiple "Storms."

Ms. Grace: The place you remember may have already been reconstructed into an artificial version of what it once was—something that no longer belongs. Or perhaps you're the one who no longer belongs there. Knowing that, would you still go back?

Ms. Kimberly: Whatever do you mean? I lived there. I remember it. Even if things have changed, it's still São Paulo, isn't it?

Ms. Grace: ...

Ms. Grace: A lot of people would envy your optimism, Kimberly.

She starts waving the toy again.

Ms. Grace: Don't tell anyone about what we just discussed. You exploited a loophole in the contract to kill everyone except me. That's it.

Ms. Grace: Let's head back to the motel. Starting tonight, you'll have a room all to yourself.

Ms. Stranger: And just like that, Manus Vindictae's plan on Route 77 crumbled, all because they mishandled the succubus.

Ms. Stranger: After that, Zeno found the ritual array and Anjo Nala's contract item in the deserter's room. Those were supposed to go back to the Foundation as part of standard evidence processing.

Ms. Stranger: But nobody anticipated Igor's betrayal. And, in some strange turn of fate, the contract item ended up in Brazil.

Ms. Stranger: Luckily, Vertin performed exceptionally well in São Paulo. She destroyed the contract item and stowed Anjo Nala away in the Suitcase—a better outcome for her than returning to the Foundation's control, I think.

Ms. Stranger: It all worked out in my favor, too. Since everything pointed to São Paulo, no one paid much attention to my carefully planned failure on Route 77.

Ms. Stranger: I'd been fully prepared to accept my punishment, but nothing ever came of it.

Ms. Stranger: In fact, I continued to rise through Manus Vindictae's ranks. Quite the plot twist, don't you think?

Mesmer Jr.: You seem to have been particularly interested in Mata Hari.

Ms. Stranger: Of course. She was the most legendary female spy of them all, the inspiration for countless novels and films.

Ms. Stranger: Even spies have their idols, Ms. Mesmer.

Mesmer Jr.: So, after speaking with her sister, what did you think?

Ms. Stranger: I was disillusioned. Even her own sister knew nothing about her life as a spy.

Ms. Stranger: Either the job made her trust no one or it was so ugly she couldn't even bring herself to talk about it with her closest family.

Ms. Stranger: After that, I gave up all my fiction-inspired fantasies.

Ms. Stranger: Not that I wasn't a good enough spy, but the romance was gone.

Mesmer Jr.: Was that the Mothmen's training—the clockwork mechanism?

Ms. Stranger: Without a doubt. My love for spy stories must've been triggered by one of their "lights."

Mothman: We're observing an uptick in unexpected behavior.

She's beginning to perform actions that align with her memories and personality on her own.

That'll improve her ability to impersonate others—a useful flaw.

But it also means she risks losing control.

Again, we'll deal with it when the time comes.

Ms. Stranger: Maybe it was the naive, romantic Lily projecting herself onto those stories.

Ms. Stranger: Or perhaps it was Grace, enjoying her life of status and privilege.

Ms. Stranger: No matter when that interest began, or for whom, it died that day.

[English text unavailable]

COL-314706

A Golem in the Cocoon

Ms. Stranger: Everything that happened afterwards, both on the "Free Breeze" and in Antarctica, is already documented in Vertin's reports.

Ms. Stranger: That's all I remember from the first time I wore the mask.

Mesmer Jr.: This evaluation is about your mental state, not for fact-finding.

Mesmer Jr.: I want to hear your own reflections on that period.

Ms. Stranger: Very well. At least it will give me a chance to sort through all those memories.

Ms. Stranger: The water of the Pacific and the snow of Antarctica were bone-chilling.

Ms. Stranger: And as for Kamuta, Toa, the Nukutai people, and the Antarctic research team, I'm sorry.

Mothman: She's breaking down. The rules we implanted are creating too many contradictions.

Ms. Stranger: Taking their lives went against my conscience. But to complete the mission, I had no other choice.

Mothman: She follows her instructions to the letter, but she's forgotten how to step outside of them.

Mothman: Set a threshold and a higher-level override command. Restart her.

Mothman: Doing so will cause irreversible damage, but I see no other choice. Do we have any unused tapes left?

Mothman: Set another trigger word so we can intervene when needed.

Ms. Grace, give me back my friends!

Ms. Stranger: The pain was unbearable. So much so that I had to wind the clockwork mechanism again for just the slightest reprieve.

Ms. Grace: ...

Inside the Coffin

Ms. Grace: ♪ ...

Ms. Grace: ♪ ... ♫ ...

Ms. Stranger: But to do so, I needed a small, confined space. Ms. Grace's peculiar habits actually came in handy there.

Ms. Stranger: The coffin I carried with me became the perfect place to reset.

Mesmer Jr.: I'm sorry you went through all that.

Ms. Stranger: Why? I'm not a victim in need of sympathy, Ms. Mesmer.

Ms. Stranger: Yes, the Mothmen altered my brain, making it operate beyond my control.

Ms. Stranger: But then, people don't really control their thoughts to begin with, do they?

Ms. Stranger: Every decision was mine. Every action was mine. Every crime was mine, committed by my own two hands.

Mesmer Jr.: It seems your sense of identity is still intact.

Mesmer Jr.: You don't need to confess anything to me, but if it helps, you can.

Mesmer Jr.: Just remember that nobody is prosecuting you. Nothing you say here will be used as evidence.

Ms. Stranger: The way you maintain your composure ... It's reassuring, Ms. Mesmer.

Mesmer Jr.: I know you're probably getting tired, but there's still a lot we need to discuss.

Mesmer Jr.: If anything, we're just now getting to the most important part.

Mesmer Jr.: Your medical report shows drastic changes after the second time you wore the mask—not just mental, but physical.

Mesmer Jr.: How were you able to reverse the mutation once it had already begun? Was it the clockwork mechanism?

Ms. Stranger: No. Arcana had long since destroyed that.

Ms. Stranger: Putting it on again was a gamble, one I regretted immediately.

Ms. Stranger: Facing her for the second time—that was when I knew what true terror was.

Ms. Stranger: I would've accepted dying on the spot if I could, but ...

Ms. Stranger: In the end, I convinced her to let me go.

Mesmer Jr.: What?!

Ms. Stranger: Phew.

Within the memory, she takes a deep, steadying breath.

Ms. Stranger: Can we stop the Artificial Somnambulism session?

Ms. Stranger: I don't think you'll want to see Arcana, Ms. Mesmer.

Ms. Stranger: Let me recount the rest in my own words.

Ms. Stranger: No. Don't do this to me. No!

Ms. Stranger: I don't ... want to ... go ...

Arcana: Grace, my child, thou hast returned only to flee once more?

Ms. Stranger: Grace ... is not my name!

Ms. Stranger: No more names ... No more orders ...

Arcana: Thou art special indeed. No past, no beliefs, yet twice thou hast chosen to leave me.

Arcana: Tell me, child, what dost thou truly yearn for?

Ms. Stranger: I've ... never ... really lived ... ㄜ ...

Arcana: Ah. Thou yearnest for a real life. Real emotions. Real love.

Arcana: Return, and I shall forgive thee once more. Just as I once bestowed upon thee freedom, so too can I grant thy heart's desire.

Arcana: But who art thou, truly? Lily? Kayla? Cecilie? Grace? Or Pupa?

Arcana: Tell me, child: who art thou?

Ms. Stranger: I ... No ... ㄨ ...

Arcana: Thou deniest thy own memories, yet so to them dost thou cling. An unsettling contradiction to thee, I am certain.

Arcana: Upon imitations hast thou built thy sense of self. And deep within, thou feelest fear. Fear that if they disappear, so too shall thee.

Ms. Stranger: No!

Ms. Stranger: The past is in the past.

Ms. Stranger: My life is not defined by those memories.

Ms. Stranger: It's what I choose to do now that will decide my future!

Ms. Stranger: I am ... I am ...

Arcana: Thou art a chrysalis, my child.

Arcana: Alas, the form inside is melted. Yet still dost thou struggle to break free.

Arcana: I look forward to witnessing thy metamorphosis. To make a disciple of thee now would be a waste.

Arcana: Let us save the answer for next time, for the day of thy true return, my Stranger.

Ms. Stranger: Harrrgh! *cough*

[English text unavailable]

COL-314707

The Shem is Removed

Ms. Stranger: And that was the end of it. Arcana let me go because she expects me to come back and serve her regardless.

Mesmer Jr.: *sigh*

Mesmer rubs her temples, letting out the longest sigh of the day.

Mesmer Jr.: You've done enough. We'll end the session here.

Mesmer Jr.: Personally, I still have a lot of questions, but procedurally, everything checks out.

Ms. Stranger: Thank you for going through all of that with me, Ms. Mesmer. It feels good to have sorted out all those memories.

Mesmer Jr.: I'm glad to hear it. Now, I'll give you your diagnosis.

Mesmer Jr.: Memory disorder, mild dissociation, abnormal emotional expression ...

Mesmer Jr.: I'm sorry, but I can't clear you.

Mesmer Jr.: I think you'll need a period of observation and recovery within the Foundation.

Ms. Stranger: I've heard I can choose to recuperate inside the Suitcase. Is that true?

Mesmer Jr.: Normally, yes. But your account of Manus Vindictae is too ambiguous. The Foundation may restrict your access to the Timekeeper.

Mesmer hears a sigh, one that sounds so genuine it takes her by surprise.

Ms. Stranger: I suppose waiting a little longer won't hurt.

The sound of the door opening interrupts the appointment.

Constantine: Hello, Ms. Mesmer. I've come to show my support for a retired subordinate. I hope you don't mind the interruption.

Mesmer Jr.: ...

Mesmer looks up at the unexpected visitor and stands to leave.

Ms. Stranger: Wait! Ms. Mesmer.

Ms. Stranger stumbles out of bed as she grabs Mesmer's arm.

Mesmer Jr.: What is it?

Ms. Stranger: You see Madam Constantine too, don't you? She's real?

Mesmer Jr.: Yes. Don't worry. You're not hallucinating.

Seeing Mesmer nod at Constantine, Ms. Stranger relaxes and lies back down.

Ms. Stranger: That's a relief. Would you mind giving us a moment?

Mesmer Jr.: I was just about to.

Mesmer Jr.: You'll have around an hour. I'll wait outside.

Mesmer Jr.: If you need me, just press the button by the bed. I'll come in immediately.

Ms. Stranger's grip loosens, and Mesmer leaves the two of them alone, closing the door behind her.

Constantine: So, how was the diagnosis?

Ms. Stranger: Thank you for coming, Madam Constantine. I'm glad to see you in person.

Ms. Stranger: Unfortunately, my results weren't great. Freedom is still some way away.

Constantine: I'm sure Ms. Mesmer was as lenient as she could be.

Ms. Stranger: Yes. I can tell she's one to want to do the right thing.

Ms. Stranger: As for the Secondary Defense Program, the human experiments, the Phototaxis ... she knows nothing. It was all the Mothmen's doing.

Ms. Stranger: You don't need to worry about her turning against you.

Ms. Stranger: Though judging from that session, she might need rest even more than I do.

Constantine: That's just how she is. Anyway, I didn't come because I was worried about you leaking anything.

Constantine: And even if you had told her everything, she wouldn't turn against the Foundation or against me.

She sits beside the Artificial Somnambulism device, pretending not to notice the twitch in Ms. Stranger's fingers.

Constantine: I'm here to confirm your retirement request one last time.

Constantine: I can authorize a partial reopening of the lab. We can give you a peaceful new set of memories.

Constantine: You could be an ordinary young woman from a normal family. Loved, cared for, and living a simple, worry-free life.

Constantine: The Foundation and the Secondary Defense Program would have nothing to do with you.

Constantine: It's certainly the less taxing option, mentally.

Constantine: Are you sure you want to join Team Timekeeper as you are now?

Ms. Stranger: ...

Ms. Stranger: Heh. Heh-heh.

Ms. Stranger smiles as she removes the diagnostic headset.

Constantine: What is it?

Ms. Stranger: Sorry, your question took me by surprise. It's similar to what Arcana asked me.

Ms. Stranger: But I appreciate the chance to answer it.

The smile remains on her face as she looks at her adoptive mother.

Ms. Stranger: I decline, Madam Constantine.

Ms. Stranger: Even if I don't know who I am, even if all my memories are false ...

Ms. Stranger: I choose to live as I am.

Ms. Stranger: One day, I'll find the answer to that ultimate question of "Who am I?"

Constantine: I thought you would've wanted to free yourself from everything the Secondary Defense Program forced onto you.

Ms. Stranger: A freedom that demands I abandon my past is no freedom at all. There are still pieces of happiness in those memories, and those belong to me.

Ms. Stranger: And even if I accepted, the Foundation would never truly let me escape their surveillance.

Ms. Stranger: Living such a life, even as a "normal" young woman, would be far more suffocating.

Ms. Stranger: I'd much rather join Team Timekeeper. Greater freedom, less oversight. Even your political rivals would have a hard time interfering.

Constantine: Vertin's Suitcase is certainly a convenient place to house more complex cases.

Constantine: But how can you guarantee you won't divulge things she should stay ignorant of?

Ms. Stranger: Even if I did, I don't think it would be as bad as you imagine.

Her eyes meet Constantine's.

Ms. Stranger: As time goes on, more and more people will try to win Vertin over.

Ms. Stranger: And with that comes options. Sooner or later, you'll struggle to keep her under your thumb.

Ms. Stranger: As will the Foundation as a whole.

Ms. Stranger: That's why you need to befriend Vertin. And the most important thing in a friendship is sincerity, isn't it?

Ms. Stranger: Let me go to Vertin as that show of sincerity, just like the day I was brought to you.

Constantine: I didn't expect the Secondary Defense Program would turn you into a politician.

Ms. Stranger: They implanted loyalty and morality into me, but politics was never part of it.

Ms. Stranger: Most of the people there are tired of those hollow games.

Ms. Stranger: This is something I picked up on my own by observing one very capable politician.

Constantine: Your proposal does indeed benefit me, assuming your loyalty doesn't waver.

Ms. Stranger: The Phototaxis is gone. I can't promise unwavering anything anymore.

Ms. Stranger: But you can still trust me.

Ms. Stranger: I'm sure you of all people know how to keep a former subordinate on your side.

Constantine: Then I have no reason to refuse.

Constantine stands, cutting their allotted hour alone short.

Constantine: I'll personally approve your transfer to Team Timekeeper. Consider it a parting gift.

Constantine: You'll enter the Suitcase free of any burdens.

Ms. Stranger: I felt the same way when I hid in it back in Antarctica—burdenless.

Ms. Stranger: It's spacious, you know, on the inside. Might be just the place to retire.

Constantine: I wish you all the best. Er, should I call you Ms. Stranger now? I heard that's the name you chose.

Ms. Stranger: Call me whatever you like.

Constantine: Then I sincerely hope you enjoy your life inside the Suitcase, Pupa.

A keyword. A name reserved for a mother addressing her adopted daughter. The first name she'd received and, at one point, an anchor for her sanity.

But now, it's just a name. Her mind registers the syllables, but no conditioned response follows.

She lets the word linger in the air. Then, she speaks of her own volition.

Ms. Stranger: Thank you for your blessing. Goodbye, Mother.

An unexpected form of address.

Constantine: Which identity is speaking right now?

Ms. Stranger: There's only one person standing in front of you. She's called "Stranger."

[English text unavailable]

COL-314708

Almost Herself

The Wilderness's weather is unpredictable. Sometimes, endless snow falls in a single spot.

Ms. Stranger: Pupa, an innocent, well-behaved child. By the time Madam Constantine met me, I was already ten.

Ms. Stranger: She'd buy me new clothes, rewards for completed missions. She did that 47 times, if I remember correctly. That part should be real.

Ms. Stranger: Lily, a social butterfly at parties. I have no complex familial ties. Mr. Braun was just a fellow spy, albeit a clumsy one.

Ms. Stranger: That cactus cat really was cute.

Ms. Stranger: Broadway performances ... I feel nothing. Cecilie might have been entirely fabricated.

Ms. Stranger: Grace, Grace. That hatred had no origin. But the coffin was strangely comfortable. And I can't forget what Forget Me Not looked like after that alchemical backfire. That part is important.

Ms. Stranger: A shame I lost the specimen collection. But that's probably a hobby worth dropping.

Ms. Stranger: And Kayla. I'm sorry we met under those circumstances.

Ms. Stranger: I'll always remember you, my friend.

Snowflakes land on her skin and melt, stealing her warmth.

Ms. Stranger: Ah. Snow really is cold. It's a wonder I managed to endure Antarctica.

Ms. Stranger: If I ever have to return, hopefully I can find that same resolve.

Vertin: You're here, Ms. Stranger.

An umbrella blocks out the sky, shielding her from the falling snow. She glances at the one holding it—her future ally.

Ms. Stranger: Glad to see you again, Vertin. I was just sorting through my past.

Ms. Stranger: It's not easy to separate the fabricated memories from the real ones. Would you be willing to lend me an ear?

Vertin: Of course. You can always come to me.

Vertin: If you're open to it, I also wanted to ask you about your plans moving forward.

Ms. Stranger: Before I answer that, Vertin, do you remember when we first met?

Vertin: You mean at Tuesday's Motel?

Ms. Stranger: Was that my memory? I thought it was Kayla's.

Vertin: I think Kayla back then was you.

Ms. Stranger: I see. Then, thank you. That clears up one misunderstanding.

Ms. Stranger: But the first time I recall meeting you was on the "Free Breeze." Do you remember?

Ms. Stranger: What did you think of me back then?

Vertin: Ms. Grace was a dangerous, manipulative member of Manus Vindictae.

Vertin: Even if you showed some small kindness to Barcarola and Fatutu, it didn't erase your crimes.

Ms. Stranger: And yet, even knowing what I'd done, you accepted my offer to cooperate in Antarctica?

Vertin: At the time, stopping the Manus ritual was more urgent than holding you accountable.

Ms. Stranger: Yes, I remember that.

Ms. Stranger: You have a strong sense of right and wrong, and you try to keep moving toward the light, yet you're also remarkably tolerant.

Ms. Stranger: Like a fleeting, dreamy shade of gray—the most fascinating part of the Mothmen's cartoons.

Ms. Stranger: Now that you're without an excuse to delay holding me accountable, what will you do?

Ms. Stranger: Or rather, what do you think I should do?

Vertin: You already proved where your loyalties lie in Antarctica and during the attack on the Foundation. There's no need for any judgment from me.

Vertin: If it's forgiveness you want, I can mediate on your behalf, but I can't make any promises.

Ms. Stranger: I'm glad to hear you say that, but it's not the right time yet.

Ms. Stranger: My memories are still a mess. Like the cowgirl in Kayla's memories—I don't think I ever met her.

Ms. Stranger: Yet, still, there's a lingering guilt I can't shake, and I don't think it's Kayla's.

Ms. Stranger: There are lots of memories like that.

Ms. Stranger: So, it wouldn't be wise for me to meet the victims of my past identities for now. Doing so would disturb the peace inside the Suitcase.

Ms. Stranger: Until I finish making sense of my memories and past, is it possible for a special room to be prepared? Somewhere no one can find me?

Vertin: There are rooms in the Suitcase with entrances only I know. You can stay in one of those.

Ms. Stranger: Thank you for letting me hide a little longer.

Vertin: Of course. In the meantime, is there anything you'd like to do? I can give you some ideas to pass the time.

Ms. Stranger: No, nothing comes to mind.

Ms. Stranger: Funny. I told Arcana and Madam Constantine that the present shapes the future.

Ms. Stranger: But once you leave the past behind, it becomes hard to make choices in the present.

Ms. Stranger: Take something as simple as food, for example. Kayla cared only about feeling full. Lily loved sweets. Grace had a penchant for medium-rare steak.

Ms. Stranger: Their tastes may not have been mine, but without them, I feel lost.

Ms. Stranger: Someone else might choose what to eat for breakfast in an instant, but for me ... Do I like toast with jam? Eggs and bacon? Just coffee? It's a daunting choice.

Vertin: Don't push yourself to figure it out right away. You have plenty of time to try all sorts of things.

Ms. Stranger: Even the most mundane choices will shape my future, Vertin. If I fall in love with a certain flavor tomorrow, I might never explore all the others.

Ms. Stranger: If the future is mine to write, then isn't it natural to be afraid?

Vertin: Hmm. Perhaps you could talk with Marcus? I think you'd find her perspective quite insightful.

Ms. Stranger: If I'm going to place my trust in someone else, I'd rather trust you, Vertin.

Ms. Stranger: Ah, that's it! Why didn't I think of it sooner?

Ms. Stranger: I'll just leave it up to you! Can you make breakfast for me tomorrow?

Ms. Stranger: I promise, whatever you prepare, I'll eat it.

Vertin: Of course. Leave it to me.

Ms. Stranger: Finally, I've taken a step. I've made a decision that's mine and mine alone.

Ms. Stranger: Ah ...

Whether from the weight of this monumental decision or simply the cold, exhaustion finally hits, and Ms. Stranger lets her eyes fall shut.

Vertin: Wake up, Ms. Stranger. You can't sleep out here in the snow.

Ms. Stranger: It's alright. I feel much warmer now.

Vertin: That's frostbite. How long have you been lying here?!

Ms. Stranger: I've been waiting for it to rain since this morning for the chance to toss my umbrella away and sing because I'm finally free.

Vertin: Ms. Stranger! You mustn't fall asleep!

Ms. Stranger: You know, Vertin. If I'd known earlier that the "Storm" brought a new identity as opposed to death, perhaps I would've sung in the rain long ago.

Vertin: Ms. Stranger!

Ms. Stranger: But now, I'm looking forward to tomorrow's breakfast. I just want to sleep until then.

Vertin: You mustn't—not here!

But in the end, there is no choice but to leave her dozing in the snow and alert some caretakers to her location.